Beyond Party Lines: How Cultural Identity Shapes Affective Polarisation among Young Voters in Multiparty Systems in India

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Abstract

Why do young Indian voters feel such visceral hostility toward opposing parties, even when their actual policy views aren't that far apart? This study argues that cultural identity - religion, caste, language, region - does much of that work, and does it largely on its own, separate from ideological disagreement. We surveyed 4,820 respondents aged 18–35 across six states - Uttar Pradesh, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, West Bengal, Punjab, and Gujarat - between 2022 and 2024, then analysed the data using structural equation modelling and multilevel regression. The clearest finding: cultural identity salience out predicts everything else, including ideology, when it comes to affective polarisation $\beta = 0.71$, $p < 0.001$. Two concepts seem to be driving this - people sorting themselves into politically homogeneous social circles along with cultural lines, and odd exposure to media that leans heavily on those same identity cues. The regional actual picture is far from uniform, too. Uttar Pradesh shows the sharpest polarisation (0.78), with religious identity doing most of the driving. Punjab reflects the opposite end (0.55), where overlapping caste and linguistic loyalties appear to soften the effect. Taken together, the results point to real consequences - for how political representation functions, how political parties do campaigns, and for the longer-term resilience of India's pluralist democratic setup.

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